ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Reduced relative clauses

Reduce defining relative clauses to present participles, past participles or infinitives when the omitted subject is recoverable. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use reduced relative clauses to compress noun modification without losing the relationship between the noun and the action while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Reduce defining relative clauses to present participles, past participles or infinitives when the omitted subject is recoverable.

MODEL

Applications received after Friday will not be considered.

noun + -ing | noun + past participle | noun + to-infinitive

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main reduced relative clauses patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses compress noun modification without losing the relationship between the noun and the action.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in descriptions, reports, instructions and concise professional writing.

Build meaning before form

Reduce defining relative clauses to present participles, past participles or infinitives when the omitted subject is recoverable.

What reduced relative clauses communicates

Reduce defining relative clauses to present participles, past participles or infinitives when the omitted subject is recoverable.

The central purpose is to compress noun modification without losing the relationship between the noun and the action. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

Students waiting outside should form one line.	an active action performed by the modified noun
Applications received after Friday will not be considered.	a passive action affecting the modified noun
Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.	purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: noun + -ing | noun + past participle | noun + to-infinitive. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “Applications received after Friday will not be considered.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Active reduction	noun + verb-ing	Students waiting outside should form one line.
Passive reduction	noun + past participle	Applications received after Friday will not be considered.
Infinitive reduction	noun + to-infinitive	Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
an active action performed by the modified noun	Active reduction
a passive action affecting the modified noun	Passive reduction
purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun	Infinitive reduction

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in descriptions, reports, instructions and concise professional writing. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05	06
noun	-ing	noun	past participle	noun	to-infinitive

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: compress noun modification without losing the relationship between the noun and the action.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits descriptions, reports, instructions and concise professional writing.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Active reduction	noun + verb-ing	Students waiting outside should form one line.
Passive reduction	noun + past participle	Applications received after Friday will not be considered.
Infinitive reduction	noun + to-infinitive	Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

Students waiting outside should form one line.	an active action performed by the modified noun
Applications received after Friday will not be considered.	a passive action affecting the modified noun
Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.	purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use an -ing reduction when the noun is not the understood subject.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not reduce when the missing relative clause contains a different subject.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use the infinitive reduction when the time or agency becomes ambiguous.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an active action performed by the modified noun?

OPTIONS Students waiting outside should form one line. · Applications received after Friday will not be considered. · Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a passive action affecting the modified noun?

OPTIONS Applications received after Friday will not be considered. · Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern. · Students waiting outside should form one line.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun?

OPTIONS Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern. · Students waiting outside should form one line. · Applications received after Friday will not be considered.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “Students waiting outside should form one line.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an active action performed by the modified noun · a passive action affecting the modified noun · purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “Applications received after Friday will not be considered.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a passive action affecting the modified noun · purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun · an active action performed by the modified noun

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun · an active action performed by the modified noun · a passive action affecting the modified noun

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“Students waiting outside should form one line.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Active reduction / Passive reduction / Infinitive reduction · Gap 2: an active action performed by the modified noun / a passive action affecting the modified noun / purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“Applications received after Friday will not be considered.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Passive reduction / Infinitive reduction / Active reduction · Gap 2: a passive action affecting the modified noun / purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun / an active action performed by the modified noun

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Infinitive reduction / Active reduction / Passive reduction · Gap 2: purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun / an active action performed by the modified noun / a passive action affecting the modified noun

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses an active action performed by the modified noun: _____. Choose the model that expresses a passive action affecting the modified noun: _____. Choose the model that expresses purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun: _____. Choose the model built with noun + verb-ing: _____. Choose the model built with noun + past participle: _____. Choose the model built with noun + to-infinitive: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

Applications received after Friday will not be considered. · Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern. · Students waiting outside should form one line.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

Students _____ should form one line. Applications _____ will not be considered. Mina was the first analyst _____ the pattern. State the full structural pattern for Active reduction: _____. State the full structural pattern for Passive reduction: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “Students who are waiting outside should form one line.” using the Active reduction pattern to express an active action performed by the modified noun.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Applications that are received after Friday will not be considered.” using the Passive reduction pattern to express a passive action affecting the modified noun.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Mina was the first analyst who identified the pattern.” using the Infinitive reduction pattern to express purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “Students who are waiting outside should form one line.” using the Active reduction pattern to express an active action performed by the modified noun.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Active reduction to express an active action performed by the modified noun, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Passive reduction to express a passive action affecting the modified noun, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Infinitive reduction to express purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

Students waiting outside should form one line.

Active reduction is the best match because an active action performed by the modified noun.

A2

Applications received after Friday will not be considered.

Passive reduction is the best match because a passive action affecting the modified noun.

A3

Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.

Infinitive reduction is the best match because purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun.

A4

an active action performed by the modified noun

The Active reduction pattern communicates an active action performed by the modified noun.

A5

a passive action affecting the modified noun

The Passive reduction pattern communicates a passive action affecting the modified noun.

A6

purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun

The Infinitive reduction pattern communicates purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Active reduction / an active action performed by the modified noun

The structure belongs to the Active reduction pattern. Its communicative purpose is an active action performed by the modified noun.

B2

Passive reduction / a passive action affecting the modified noun

The structure belongs to the Passive reduction pattern. Its communicative purpose is a passive action affecting the modified noun.

B3

Infinitive reduction / purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun

The structure belongs to the Infinitive reduction pattern. Its communicative purpose is purpose, obligation or ordinal selection linked to a noun.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

Students waiting outside should form one line.

Active reduction: noun + verb-ing.

C2

Applications received after Friday will not be considered.

Passive reduction: noun + past participle.

C3

Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.

Infinitive reduction: noun + to-infinitive.

C4

Students waiting outside should form one line.

Active reduction: noun + verb-ing.

C5

Applications received after Friday will not be considered.

Passive reduction: noun + past participle.

C6

Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.

Infinitive reduction: noun + to-infinitive.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

waiting outside

Active reduction requires “waiting outside” in this model. noun + verb-ing.

D2

received after Friday

Passive reduction requires “received after Friday” in this model. noun + past participle.

D3

to identify

Infinitive reduction requires “to identify” in this model. noun + to-infinitive.

D4

noun + verb-ing

Active reduction is built as noun + verb-ing.

D5

noun + past participle

Passive reduction is built as noun + past participle.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

Students waiting outside should form one line.

noun + verb-ing. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended active reduction effect.

E2

Applications received after Friday will not be considered.

noun + past participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended passive reduction effect.

E3

Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern.

noun + to-infinitive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended infinitive reduction effect.

E4

Students waiting outside should form one line.

noun + verb-ing. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended active reduction effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

Students waiting outside should form one line. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses noun + verb-ing accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

Applications received after Friday will not be considered. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses noun + past participle accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

Mina was the first analyst to identify the pattern. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses noun + to-infinitive accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____